

Montana Artificial Intelligence in K–12 Education Guidelines

Prepared primarily for Montana district and school leaders, with guidance for educators, families, school boards, and policymakers

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Welcome and Acknowledgments

Thank you for reviewing this second version of the *Montana Artificial Intelligence in K–12 Education Guidelines*, referred to throughout this document as the Montana AI Guidelines. The guidelines support district leaders as they develop and refine local guidance, policy, professional learning, and implementation practices. Grounded in Montana's educational vision, they provide a foundation for responsible AI use, stronger AI literacy, and local systems that can adapt as technology changes.

The Montana Office of Public Instruction (OPI), in collaboration with the Frontier Learning Lab at the Montana Digital Academy (MTDA) and key education partners, leads the development and twice-annual revision of this guidance. We extend our gratitude to everyone who contributed to the drafting process. The Montana School Boards Association provides complementary model-policy resources for local boards and districts, and we thank them for their leadership.

This work reflects Montana's rural, urban, and tribal communities. Its purpose is to support safe, ethical, and locally responsive AI use that expands access and educational opportunity for Montana students.

Thank you for your partnership,

Susie Hedalen
Superintendent of Public Instruction



Jason Neiffer
Executive Director, Montana Digital Academy



How to Use These Guidelines

The Montana AI Guidelines are designed primarily for district and school leaders developing local guidance, policy, and implementation plans. They also provide context for educators, families, school boards, and policymakers.

These guidelines address the selection, governance, and instructional use of artificial intelligence tools only. They do not address the amount of time students spend using technology, one-to-one device programs, personal-device policy, or screen-based instruction generally. Those decisions rest with local boards and districts, and nothing in this document is intended as guidance on them.

These guidelines are advisory. They support local decision-making and do not replace local board policy, district procedures, professional judgment, or advice from qualified legal and accessibility experts. Montana districts vary widely in size, staffing, connectivity, resources, and community priorities; each district should adapt the recommendations to its local circumstances while meeting applicable requirements.

Readers new to this work can begin with **Core Principles for AI Integration** and **Getting Started: Three Immediate Actions**. The **Implementation Roadmap** supports longer-term planning and improvement. **Universal Access and Learner-Centered Design** address barriers affecting learners and local implementation. **Safety, Privacy, and Responsible Procurement** provide practical safeguards for tool review and synthetic-media response.

Throughout the document, recommendations describe strong practices for local consideration. Mandatory language applies to obligations arising from applicable law or locally adopted policy, not from the Montana AI Guidelines themselves.

Benefits and Risks of AI in Education

Artificial intelligence may support K–12 education in useful ways, but its value and risks depend on the tool, purpose, learner, and implementation. Districts should consider potential benefits alongside foreseeable harms, local capacity, and available safeguards.

Benefits

- **Differentiated instructional materials:** AI may help educators draft or adapt materials for different reading levels, background knowledge, languages, or learning needs. Educators remain responsible for reviewing the accuracy, suitability, and accessibility of those materials.
- **Educator capacity:** AI may reduce time spent on some routine drafting, formatting, and planning tasks. When those uses produce reliable results, educators may have more time for direct student support, instructional decisions, and relationship-building.
- **Accessibility support:** Features such as text prediction, translation, speech-to-text, and text-to-speech may improve access for some students with disabilities or language needs when selected and implemented appropriately.
- **Simulation and exploration:** AI may support simulations, guided practice, and exploration of real-world scenarios that would otherwise be difficult to reproduce in a classroom.

Risks

- **Bias, inaccuracy, and misinformation:** AI systems may produce false, incomplete, or biased outputs that appear credible. Unreviewed output can mislead students, educators, and families.
- **Overreliance:** When AI performs important parts of a learning task, students may have fewer opportunities to practice critical thinking, problem-solving, and productive struggle.
- **Substituting AI for human instruction:** AI use that replaces discussion, collaboration, or educator feedback may reduce interactions that matter for learning. Districts should consider what an AI tool is being asked to do in place of a person.
- **Barriers to access:** Tools that require reliable broadband, current devices, paid subscriptions, or specialized staff may be difficult for some districts and students to use.
- **Data collection and monitoring:** Tools that collect extensive student information, including some assessment and monitoring systems, may create privacy and security risks and may generate detailed records of student activity beyond what the original purpose requires.
- **Developmental and ethical concerns:** Student age, maturity, learning goals, and the sensitivity of the activity should inform whether and how an AI tool is used.

AI and Teaching and Learning

Section 1: Core Principles for AI Integration

AI use in Montana classrooms should be driven by instructional needs, not technological novelty. District policies and practices should reflect the following principles:

1. Evidence-Driven Adoption: Districts should evaluate AI tools using credible research, local instructional priorities, and observed results rather than relying on vendor claims alone. Evidence is emerging and varies by tool, learner, subject, and use case. Improvements in immediate task performance do not necessarily demonstrate independent mastery, long-term retention, or transfer to new contexts. Districts may conduct limited, well-designed pilots with clear learning goals, a human in the loop, and a plan for evaluating results before expanding use.

2. Preserving Productive Struggle: Learning requires cognitive effort. AI tools can reduce friction and provide immediate answers, but easier does not always mean better. Educators should use AI to support learning rather than bypass the critical thinking, problem-solving, practice, and productive struggle that learning requires.

3. The Human in the Loop: AI output does not replace professional judgment, empathy, or pedagogical expertise. Educators remain responsible for reviewing and verifying AI-generated content used in the classroom and for the instructional decisions surrounding its use.

4. Protect Student Data: Districts should establish clear processes for reviewing and approving AI tools, minimizing the collection and sharing of student information, and communicating permitted uses. Educators should use locally approved tools and avoid entering protected or sensitive information unless specifically authorized. Local review processes should account for applicable federal and Montana privacy requirements, vendor data practices, security, and potential bias.

Section 2: Guidance for Educator Use

Reducing administrative burden is a promising and comparatively lower-risk use of AI in education. For some specific, repetitive tasks, AI may save educators time that can be redirected toward student interaction and instruction. Districts should evaluate whether a tool produces reliable results, protects sensitive information, and creates meaningful time savings in local practice.

Potential Uses for Educators:

- **Routine drafting and formatting:** Preparing draft newsletters, general communications, forms, and other materials without entering protected information into an unapproved tool.
- **Instructional preparation:** Drafting differentiated reading passages, practice questions, examples, and possible lesson openings.
- **Rubrics and explanations:** Creating a starting point for a rubric or generating alternative explanations and analogies for educator review.

Professional Responsibility for Verification: Generative AI can produce factual errors, fabricated information, and biased output. Educators should independently review AI-generated materials for accuracy, age appropriateness, accessibility, and respect for Montana's people before using them with students.

Section 3: Guidance for Student Learning

Student-facing AI is changing rapidly. District guidance should distinguish acceptable assistance from academic dishonesty and give students clear boundaries for each learning activity.

Understanding the Evidence Gap: Research on student-facing AI is developing rapidly, and findings vary across tools, subjects, age groups, and instructional designs. Stronger performance on a task completed with AI assistance does not by itself demonstrate independent mastery, retention, or transfer. Districts and educators may choose to test promising uses on a limited basis, with clear learning goals, appropriate safeguards, and a plan to evaluate whether students can demonstrate learning without the tool.

Establishing Boundaries for Student Use: Districts should establish a simple continuum that communicates three conditions: AI use is not permitted, AI use is permitted within stated boundaries, or AI use is expected as part of the learning activity. Districts and educators determine when each condition applies based on local policy, student age, subject, learning purpose, assignment design, and accessibility needs.

- **When AI Use Is Not Permitted:** Educators may restrict AI when students need to develop or demonstrate foundational knowledge and skills independently.
- **When AI Use Is Permitted Within Boundaries:** Educators may allow defined uses of AI, such as brainstorming, receiving feedback, exploring a historical perspective, or asking for another explanation of a complex concept. The permitted uses should be stated clearly for the activity.
- **When AI Use Is Expected:** Educators may require AI use when it is itself part of the learning goal, such as evaluating AI output, practicing responsible use, or demonstrating AI literacy.
- **Disclosure Expectations:** Districts and educators should clearly communicate when and how students are expected to disclose AI assistance. Expectations should reflect student age, subject, assignment purpose, accessibility needs, and local academic-integrity policy. Minor assistance, accessibility supports, and substantial AI-generated contributions may warrant different forms of disclosure.
- **Demonstrating Learning:** When independent mastery or authorship matters, educators should use appropriate ways for students to demonstrate their learning. Depending on the task, this may include discussing their decisions, showing selected stages of their process, revising in response to questions, or completing part of the work independently.

Clear boundaries can help students use AI responsibly while continuing to develop independent knowledge, skills, and judgment.

Universal Access and Learner-Centered Design

Montana's rural, urban, and tribal communities differ in geography, local capacity, connectivity, language, and student needs. Districts should consider those differences when selecting and implementing AI so that the technology does not create new barriers to learning.

Accessibility should be considered from the beginning, not added after a tool has been selected. Universal Design for Learning (UDL), the framework developed by the Center for Applied Special Technology (CAST), helps educators anticipate learner variability and remove barriers during design. Applying UDL principles during selection and implementation can reduce the need for costly or incomplete changes later, which is particularly important for small and rural districts with limited resources.

Two related ideas should guide local decisions. First, UDL and assistive technology work together but serve different purposes: UDL builds flexibility into instruction, while assistive technology responds to an individual student's documented needs. Second, consistent with CAST's Center on Inclusive Technology in Education Systems (CITES) model, districts should coordinate assistive technology, educational technology, and information technology decisions so that accessibility is considered whenever a tool enters a classroom.

Guiding Principles

- **Remove Barriers to Learning:** AI use should expand educational opportunity and not narrow it. Districts should identify and address barriers related to disability, geography, connectivity, language, cost, and local capacity, and should consider both the barriers an AI tool may create and the barriers it may remove.
- **Design for Access from the Start:** Districts should select and implement AI tools using UDL principles, including multiple means of engagement, representation, and expression. Where possible, evaluations should include input or evidence from the learners the tools are intended to serve, including students with disabilities and multilingual learners.
- **Meet Accessibility and Disability Requirements:** AI tools must support compliance with the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA), Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act, and Section 508, and should conform to recognized standards such as WCAG 2.1 AA. Note that the updated ADA Title II rule extends WCAG conformance requirements to the web content and mobile applications of public schools on a phased timeline. Districts should confirm current compliance dates with legal counsel.
- **Cultural Relevance and Respect:** AI may support instruction, but meeting Indian Education for All requires educator expertise to ensure that content and teaching strategies remain culturally relevant and respectful. AI does not replace this judgment. Districts and educators should honor tribes' existing guidance and established approaches to delivering tribal content when considering the use of AI tools in education.

Recommended Practices

- **Require accessibility evidence during vetting.** Vendors should document how their tools support students with disabilities and multilingual learners. Independent verification, such as CAST's UDL Product Certification, may provide additional evidence for purchasing decisions. This practice connects directly to the Vendor Vetting Checklist in **Safety, Privacy, and Responsible Procurement**.
- **Build educator capacity for accessible use.** AI capabilities are increasingly incorporated into assistive technologies such as text-to-speech and speech recognition, but educators need support to use them

appropriately. The Frontier Learning Lab can help districts connect AI tools, UDL practice, and accessible educational materials at no cost.

- **Recognize the limits.** AI-enabled assistive tools may support student autonomy, engagement, and access to content, but accuracy, infrastructure, and educator readiness can limit their usefulness. A human should remain in the loop.
- **Consider where barriers are greatest.** When allocating funding or implementation assistance, districts and supporting organizations should consider barriers related to geography, connectivity, staffing, cost, and student needs.

Getting Started: Three Immediate Actions

Moving from principles to daily practice requires local processes that support educators, protect students, and honor Montana's tradition of local control.

These three immediate actions give district leaders a practical starting point. They are not a complete implementation process; the Implementation Roadmap later in this document provides a longer-term path for developing, monitoring, and improving local practice.

Step 1: Assemble a Local AI Guidance Team

AI decisions should not fall solely to an IT department or a single administrator. Because AI affects instruction, data privacy, procurement, accessibility, student conduct, and community expectations, districts should establish a cross-functional team or comparable local process to guide implementation.

Possible Participants:

- **District administrators:** Provide oversight, coordinate local processes, and identify needed resources.
- **Technology staff:** Review vendor data practices, security, system compatibility, and technical controls.
- **Instructional leaders:** Connect AI decisions to academic standards, curriculum, assessment, and learning goals.
- **Educators:** Contribute classroom experience and evaluate how tools affect teaching and learning.
- **School board and community representatives:** Support transparency and bring local values and concerns into the process.
- **Students:** Offer insights into daily classroom use, student needs, and peer perspectives on academic integrity and responsible AI use.

The Team's Work: Depending on local governance and assigned authority, the team may review state guidance, recommend local policy, identify AI features already present in district software, support tool review, and help maintain an approved-tool list. Local boards retain authority for policies requiring board adoption. The team should also consider model-policy resources from the Montana School Boards Association (MTSBA).

Smaller districts may combine roles, use an existing committee, or work with regional schools, curriculum consortia, the Frontier Learning Lab, or the Montana Educational Technologist Association.

Step 2: Provide Evidence-Informed Professional Learning

Before introducing AI tools to students, districts should prepare the employees responsible for selecting, supervising, or supporting those uses. Professional learning should extend beyond tool demonstrations to address AI literacy, instructional purpose, data privacy, accessibility, verification, and appropriate uses for routine work.

Support from the Frontier Learning Lab: Districts may use no-cost support from the Frontier Learning Lab at MTDA as they develop local professional learning.

- **AI Help Desk:** Educators and administrators can contact the Frontier Learning Lab AI Help Desk at ai.help@mtda.org for person-to-person support with tool review, prompting, local guidance, and related questions.
- **Role-specific learning:** Professional learning should prepare educators to remain the human in the loop by reviewing AI-generated content for accuracy, appropriateness, and accessibility before using it with students, families, or the community.

Step 3: Engage the Community and Communicate Clearly

AI creates new questions about how student work is produced, supported, and evaluated. Districts should clearly communicate local expectations to students, families, employees, and the broader community.

Suggested steps include:

- **Review existing policies:** Consider whether acceptable-use policies, academic-integrity policies, student handbooks, employee guidance, or related local documents need to address AI.
- **Communicate approved uses:** Tell students, families, and employees which tools and uses are locally approved and where they can ask questions.
- **Create opportunities for discussion:** Explain why the district is considering AI, what safeguards apply, how student information is protected, and how the district will respond to misuse, including malicious synthetic media and violations of academic integrity expectations.

These steps provide a practical starting point. Districts can adapt the participants, sequence, and scope to their governance structure, resources, and community priorities.

Policy and Governance

AI policy and governance in Montana should reflect the state's legal framework, cultural commitments, local-control tradition, and rural context. District policies and practices must comply with applicable law and should respond to local needs and community priorities.

Constitutional Players

Montana's education governance distributes authority among several constitutional players: the Legislature, the Governor, the Board of Public Education, the Board of Regents of Higher Education, the Superintendent of Public Instruction, and local school boards.

The Legislature establishes statutory frameworks and funding parameters that shape technology adoption. The Governor may coordinate cross-agency initiatives and workforce priorities. The Board of Public Education establishes administrative rules, educator-preparation standards, and accreditation requirements. The Board of Regents oversees higher education policy. The Superintendent of Public Instruction provides guidance and technical assistance to districts. Within this broader framework, local school boards make decisions about locally adopted policy, tool approval, staff preparation, and student-use expectations.

MTSBA provides complementary guidance for local policy development and district implementation. Current resources are available at mtda.link/mtsbaaipolicy.

Tribal Sovereignty and Consultation

Tribal nations possess inherent sovereignty that predates the United States. In education, the Montana Constitution states that "The state recognizes the distinct and unique cultural heritage of the American Indians and is committed in its educational goals to the preservation of their cultural integrity."

Montana's constitutional commitment is reflected in Indian Education for All, which requires instruction about the distinct and unique cultural heritage of American Indians. This responsibility requires accurate, culturally respectful teaching about Montana's tribal nations and communities.

In the context of AI, tribes maintain jurisdiction over their data and digital materials, possess authority to regulate technology that affects their communities, and determine whether and how AI systems interact with their cultural knowledge. Those developing AI policy must recognize tribal authority and engage in meaningful consultation when state initiatives could affect tribal communities, cultural materials, or data-sovereignty rights.

Local Control and Rural Realities

Montana's commitment to local control places many AI implementation decisions with local boards and districts. Small and rural districts may have limited technology staffing, broadband access, budgets, or procurement capacity. They may choose to work with regional cooperatives, state-supported resources, or shared-service arrangements when evaluating and implementing tools. Districts should consider connectivity, remote administration, staff workload, community values, and demonstrated educational value before adopting a tool.

Higher Education and Workforce Connections

Districts should consider connections among K–12 education, educator preparation, higher education, and workforce development. The Montana University System can support educator preparation and research that informs local AI decisions.

Legal Considerations and Liability

AI use can create legal and operational responsibilities involving privacy, accessibility, procurement, student conduct, intellectual property, records, and other areas. District leaders should use established review processes and seek qualified advice when a proposed use presents legal or liability questions.

Safety, Privacy, and Responsible Procurement

Districts need a consistent review process to protect students, meet applicable requirements, and manage local risk. The following guidance applies to every AI tool under consideration, including pilots and free versions.

Part A: Vendor Vetting Checklist

Districts should not deploy an AI tool unless the local review process verifies each of the following criteria:

- **Privacy and data protection:** The tool and its proposed use must comply with the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) and other applicable federal and Montana student-privacy requirements. Review what information the tool collects, how it is used, whether it is shared, how long it is retained, and how it can be deleted.
- **Security:** The vendor should provide evidence of appropriate security practices, incident-response procedures, and notification terms. Districts should understand which responsibilities belong to the vendor and which remain local.
- **Algorithmic bias:** Districts should require vendors to provide available documentation about how the system has been evaluated for bias.
- **Age, notice, and consent:** The proposed use must comply with the Children's Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA), vendor age restrictions, and applicable federal, Montana, and local requirements for family notice, consent, and school authorization. Districts should communicate approved tools and their data practices to families, consistent with Getting Started: Three Immediate Actions.
- **Design and engagement practices:** Districts should review whether a tool uses features intended to maximize time spent in the product rather than support learning, such as streaks, variable rewards, autoplay, persistent notifications, or personas that encourage prolonged interaction. Vendors should disclose these features, and districts should confirm which of them can be disabled.
- **Accessibility:** The vendor should provide evidence that the tool supports applicable accessibility requirements and the needs of students with disabilities and multilingual learners.
- **Contract and data-privacy terms:** The vendor must sign the Montana Student Data Privacy Agreement or an equivalent agreement approved through the district's established review process.

The Frontier Learning Lab periodically reviews tools for use in Montana schools. Tools that complete this process and meet MTDA and University of Montana procurement standards are available through the MTDA Catalog.

Part B: Deepfake and Synthetic Media Protocol

Malicious synthetic media can seriously harm students, employees, school climate, and community trust. Districts should address nonconsensual and malicious deepfakes directly in local policy and incident-response procedures.

- **Zero tolerance for malicious creation or distribution:** Local policy must classify the creation or distribution of nonconsensual deepfakes depicting students or employees as a severe offense comparable to severe bullying or harassment.
- **Immediate law-enforcement collaboration:** Explicit synthetic media involving minors may constitute child sexual abuse material (CSAM) or otherwise implicate sexual-exploitation laws. Administrators must

immediately involve local law enforcement and the Montana Department of Justice when explicit deepfakes are discovered.
- **Support for the targeted person:** The district's first response must center the safety, privacy, and support needs of the targeted student or employee. Districts must provide clear reporting pathways designed to reduce retaliation, unnecessary redistribution, and further public exposure.

Part C: Companion and Conversational AI

Students may encounter general-purpose chatbots and companion-style AI that are designed to sustain conversation and can present as confidants. Even when these tools are not district-provided, staff will encounter their effects, and districts should be prepared to respond.

- Understand the distinct risks: Conversational systems may provide inaccurate or harmful guidance, respond inappropriately to disclosures about self-harm or abuse, encourage prolonged emotional reliance, or collect sensitive personal information a student would not otherwise share.
- Do not treat AI as a support service: AI tools are not counseling, assessment, or crisis services, and should not be presented to students as a substitute for school counselors, qualified staff, or family support.
- Apply existing safety procedures: A student disclosure of harm, threat, or crisis warrants the district's established response regardless of whether the disclosure occurred in conversation with an AI system. Staff should understand that these procedures apply.
- Review companion-style tools separately: Tools designed to sustain an ongoing relationship with a student warrant review beyond the standard checklist, including whether the design encourages emotional dependence and whether age-appropriate safeguards exist.
- Communicate with families: Districts should include conversational AI in family communication about approved tools, local expectations, and how to raise a concern.

Implementation Roadmap

After completing the three immediate actions outlined earlier, districts can use this longer-term roadmap to develop and refine local implementation. The sequence is flexible; districts may adapt it to their governance structure, resources, priorities, and experience.

Capacity-Building Support

- **MTDA and the Frontier Learning Lab:** These organizations can provide professional learning and technical support for local planning, tool review, and implementation.
- **Regional cooperatives:** These organizations may provide professional learning, collaborative networks, or shared technical expertise for districts that cannot sustain those functions independently.
- **State education organizations:** MTSBA, School Administrators of Montana, the Montana Rural Education Association, the Montana Small School Alliance, and other education organizations may provide guidance and professional learning.
- **Higher education partners:** Universities, community colleges, and tribal colleges may support joint professional learning, research, and educator preparation.

I. Establish a Foundation and Local Vision

Build on the three immediate actions by documenting local purpose, decision-making responsibilities, and priorities.

- **Define purpose and goals:** Explain which local needs or opportunities AI may address and how proposed uses connect to district priorities and learning goals.
- **Confirm participation and responsibility:** Review whether the local team or process includes the knowledge and perspectives needed for the decisions under consideration. Districts determine participation based on local governance and community context.
- **Build shared understanding:** Provide appropriate orientation for district leaders, board members, educators, and others involved in local decisions so they understand AI's potential uses, limits, and risks.

II. Develop Policies and Practices for Responsible Use

This stage connects local AI use to existing policy, safeguards, and community expectations.

- **Review existing policies:** Determine whether academic-integrity, acceptable-use, privacy, grading, records, accessibility, employee-use, and digital-citizenship policies adequately address AI.

- **Use consistent principles:** Connect local policy to privacy, transparency, accountability, universal access, the human in the loop, and academic integrity.

- **Communicate clearly:** Explain locally approved uses, foreseeable risks, safeguards, and ways for the community to ask questions or provide feedback.

- **Apply the vendor-vetting checklist:** Use the review process in **Safety, Privacy, and Responsible Procurement** for every tool under consideration. Do not enter personally identifiable information into an unapproved tool.

- **Keep a human in the loop:** Educators remain responsible for reviewing AI-generated materials and for the instructional decisions surrounding their use.

III. Build Capacity Through Professional Learning

Professional learning should reflect employee roles and locally approved uses.

- **Provide role-specific learning:** Address AI literacy, instructional purpose, privacy, accessibility, verification, and practical strategies relevant to each role.

- **Support structured practice:** Give educators appropriate opportunities to test approved tools, evaluate output, reflect on benefits and risks, and learn with colleagues.

- **Develop appropriate AI literacy:** Determine what employees and students need to understand about AI, its limitations, and responsible use based on their roles and learning needs.

IV. Support Universal Access and Local Implementation

Districts should consider whether proposed uses create or remove barriers related to disability, geography, connectivity, language, cost, staffing, or local capacity.

- **Consider access requirements:** Review the devices, connectivity, tools, support, and local capacity required for a proposed use.

- **Pilot before expanding:** When appropriate, begin with a limited use, evaluate local experience, and address problems before expanding.

- **Adapt to local capacity:** Small and rural districts may use cooperative or shared arrangements when those options fit local needs.

- **Consider partnerships:** Districts may work with universities, tribal colleges, workforce programs, or other partners when those relationships support local goals.

- **Use learner-centered design:** Prioritize tools that meet applicable accessibility requirements and support students with disabilities and multilingual learners.

V. Monitor, Reflect, and Improve

Because tools, evidence, law, and local experience change, districts should review their practices regularly.

- **Review twice annually:** Examine local policies and practices as part of the Montana AI Guidelines review cycle and revise them when local needs or material changes warrant action.

- **Invite feedback:** Provide appropriate ways for students, employees, families, and community members to share local experience and concerns.

- **Reflect on Local Experience:** Periodically review educator and student experience, observed instructional value, implementation problems, privacy or safety incidents, and whether continued use remains worthwhile. Districts should avoid collecting new student-level data solely to monitor AI implementation unless a clear local need and appropriate safeguards justify it.

- **Share useful lessons:** When appropriate, share local experience with other Montana districts and support organizations.

The Frontier Learning Lab provides statewide support for local planning and implementation. Contact the AI Help Desk at ai.help@mtda.org.

Glossary

This glossary defines terms used materially in the Montana AI Guidelines.

Artificial intelligence (AI): Computer systems designed to perform tasks such as recognizing speech, analyzing data, making predictions, or generating content.

Generative AI: AI that produces content such as text, images, audio, video, or code in response to a user's instructions.

Algorithm: A set of rules or instructions a computer follows to perform a task, analyze information, or produce an output.

Bias in AI: Patterns in a system's data, design, or operation that can produce systematically unfair, inaccurate, or unrepresentative results.

Data privacy: The rights, rules, and practices governing how personal information is collected, used, stored, retained, shared, and deleted.

AI literacy: The knowledge and skills needed to understand, evaluate, and use AI appropriately, including recognizing its capabilities, limitations, risks, and effects.

Academic integrity: Honesty and responsibility in learning and academic work, including following stated expectations for assistance, attribution, and independent work.

Human in the loop: A person who actively reviews AI output, applies professional or contextual judgment, and remains responsible for the resulting decision or action.

References

This working list includes peer-state guidance, national and international resources, and Montana constitutional and statutory anchors used during drafting.

State Guidance Documents

- Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education. *Guidance for Artificial Intelligence in K–12 Education*. Massachusetts DESE, 2024.
- Utah State Board of Education. *Artificial Intelligence in Education Guidance*. Utah State Board of Education, 2024.
- Wyoming Department of Education. *Artificial Intelligence Guidance for Schools*. Wyoming Department of Education, 2024.
- Colorado Department of Education. *AI Guidance for Educators*. Colorado Department of Education, 2024.
- North Carolina Department of Public Instruction. *Generative AI Implementation Recommendations and Considerations for PK–13 Public Schools*. NCDPI, 2024.
- Montana School Boards Association. *Model Policies for Artificial Intelligence Integration in Education*. MTSBA, 2025.

National and International Resources

- International Society for Technology in Education (ISTE). *ISTE Standards for Students and Educators*. ISTE, 2023. iste.org/standards
- Computer Science Teachers Association (CSTA). *K–12 Computer Science Standards*. CSTA, 2023. csteachers.org/k12standards
- Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) and European Commission. *Empowering Learners for the Age of AI: An AI Literacy Framework for Primary and Secondary Education*. OECD Publishing, 2026. doi.org/10.1787/65cd27d4-en
- National Center on Education and the Economy (NCEE). *AI in Education Initiatives*. NCEE, 2025. ncee.org

Montana Constitutional and Statutory Anchors

- Montana Office of Public Instruction. *Indian Education for All—Essential Understandings Regarding Montana Indians*. OPI. Indian Education for All
- Montana Secretary of State. *Administrative Rules of Montana (ARM) 10.55—Accreditation Standards*. State of Montana. ARM 10.55

- Montana Secretary of State. *Administrative Rules of Montana (ARM) 10.57—Educator Licensure*. State of Montana. ARM 10.57

- Montana Legislature. *Montana Code Annotated, Title 20—Education*. State of Montana, 2024. Montana Code Annotated, Title 20

- Montana Legislature. *Montana Student Online Personal Information Protection Act*. State of Montana, 2019. Montana Code Annotated § 20-10-1501

How These Guidelines Are Reviewed

These guidelines are reviewed twice annually through a six-month participation and revision process. The process is designed to keep the guidance responsive to changes in artificial intelligence, education practice, policy, research, and Montana's local context while preserving time for focused discussion and careful review.

Months 1–3: Nominations and Participation

- Invite nominations for contributors to the next revision cycle.
- Clarify the perspectives, roles, and communities that should be represented.
- Collect candidate information and confirm participation.
- Gather initial observations and proposed topics for revision.

Months 4–6: Discussion and Revision

- Close the nomination phase so the revision group can focus on the submitted priorities.
- Conduct focused discussions about proposed revisions.
- Review evidence, policy developments, implementation experience, and stakeholder feedback.
- Draft, reconcile, edit, verify, and approve the next version.

Each review does not necessarily require a new published version. Revisions are released when the review identifies changes that materially improve the guidance's accuracy, usefulness, or relevance.

How AI Supported the Development of This Document

The Montana AI Guidelines were developed through a collaborative process led by OPI, the Frontier Learning Lab at MTDA, and partner educators. AI tools assisted with research, drafting, synthesis, and document design. Human authors remained responsible for reviewing AI-generated material and making editorial and policy decisions.

Specific uses of AI include:

- **Comparative research:** AI assisted with reviewing and summarizing guidance from peer states and national and international frameworks.
- **Updated research:** AI assisted with searches for recent state guidance and research concerning AI in K–12 education.
- **Draft support:** AI suggested language for principles, implementation pathways, and glossary definitions. Human authors reviewed and revised that material.
- **Document design:** AI tools assisted with illustrative graphics, including draft cover artwork.

Keeping a Human in the Loop

AI was not assigned final responsibility for policy determinations or high-stakes judgments. Human authors reviewed, edited, or replaced AI-generated material and retained responsibility for the document's content.